Welcome, Let's Get You Set Up 🎉

We're looking forward to spending the day building with you. So we can jump straight into the good stuff (agent mode, prompt files, MCP, and the hands-on exercises), please run through the short setup below **before the workshop**.

It shouldn't take long. If anything misbehaves, give your facilitator a shout ahead of time rather than on the morning. Much easier to sort out together when we're not against the clock.

See you soon. 🙌

1. VS Code (Latest Stable)

Download and install from code.visualstudio.com.

Verify:

```
code --version
```

> **Why VS Code?** This workshop uses VS Code as the common environment. The patterns you learn transfer to JetBrains and Visual Studio, but the exercises are built for VS Code.

2. GitHub Copilot Extensions

Install both extensions from the VS Code Extensions panel (`Ctrl+Shift+X` / `Cmd+Shift+X`):

- **GitHub Copilot**: inline completions
- **GitHub Copilot Chat**: chat, agent mode, prompt files

Verify: Open the Command Palette (`Ctrl+Shift+P` / `Cmd+Shift+P`) and type `GitHub Copilot: Status` . You should see Copilot is active.

3. GitHub Copilot License

You need an active **GitHub Copilot Business** or **Enterprise** license. Verify by signing into GitHub in VS Code and checking that Copilot suggestions appear when you type code.

If you see "Copilot is not available" or a subscription prompt, contact your GitHub admin.

4. Enable Agent Mode

Agent mode is central to this workshop. Enable it in VS Code:

1. Open Settings (`Ctrl+,` / `Cmd+,`)
2. Search for `chat.agent.enabled`
3. Ensure it is **checked** (enabled)

Verify: Open Copilot Chat (`Ctrl+Shift+I` / `Cmd+Shift+I`) and check that the mode selector at the top shows **Agent** as an option alongside Ask and Edit.

5. Enable Chat Participant Detection

This helps Copilot automatically route requests to the right tool.

1. Open Settings
2. Search for `chat.participantDetection.enabled`
3. Ensure it is **checked**

6. Git

Install Git from git-scm.com if not already installed.

Verify:

```
git --version
```

7. Your Programming Language Toolchain

Install the toolchain you use daily. The labs are language-agnostic, but you will write real code in your preferred language during exercises.

Language	Install	Verify
.NET	dotnet.microsoft.com	`dotnet --version`
Python	python.org	`python --version`
Node.js/TypeScript	nodejs.org	`node --version`
Java	adoptium.net	`java --version`

Install the corresponding VS Code extension for your language (C# Dev Kit, Python, etc.).

8. Clone This Repository

```
git clone https://github.com/hosseinzahed/github-copilot-hands-on-lab.git
cd github-copilot-hands-on-lab
```

9. Recommended VS Code Settings

These settings optimize your Copilot experience for the workshop. Open Settings JSON (`Ctrl+Shift+P` → "Preferences: Open User Settings (JSON)") and add:

```
{
  // Copilot inline suggestions
  "editor.inlineSuggest.enabled": true,

  // Auto-save to reduce friction during agent mode
  "files.autoSave": "afterDelay",
  "files.autoSaveDelay": 1000,

  // Show Copilot completions alongside other suggestions
  "editor.suggest.showInlineCompletions": true
}
```

Pre-Workshop Checklist

Before you arrive, confirm:

- [ ] VS Code latest stable installed
- [ ] GitHub Copilot and GitHub Copilot Chat extensions installed and active
- [ ] Copilot license verified (suggestions appear when coding)
- [ ] Agent mode enabled in settings
- [ ] Git installed
- [ ] Your language toolchain installed
- [ ] This repository cloned locally
- [ ] You can open Copilot Chat and switch between Ask, Edit, and Agent modes

Troubleshooting

Copilot not suggesting anything: - Check you are signed into GitHub in VS Code (bottom-left avatar) - Verify your license at github.com/settings/copilot - Reload VS Code window (`Ctrl+Shift+P` → "Developer: Reload Window")

Agent mode not showing: - Update VS Code to the latest version - Update both Copilot extensions to latest - Check `chat.agent.enabled` is true in settings

Extensions not installing: - Check your network/proxy settings allow access to the VS Code Marketplace - Try installing from VSIX if marketplace is blocked (get VSIX from your facilitator)